

Audio-Technica ATH-M20XBT

Special in its own right

The Audio-Technica ATH-M20XBT is the legendary audio brand's entry into the mid-range segment of the Bluetooth headphones market. When the M20XBT showed up at the Digit Test Centre, my first question was, what is the positioning that the brand is looking for in the market with these headphones? And, that wasn't the only question. There were many more. Let's look at what I found while testing –

BUILD AND DESIGN

Audio-Technica did not let us down with this pair of headphones. During my time using these headphones, I never found myself feeling the headband or the earcups digging into my skull. The headphones are lightweight and stay on my head well. The clamping force might be on the lower side for some. There's the swivel in the earcups too, which makes up for the inherent lack of clamping force on these headphones. The metallic headband instilled quite a bit of confidence in me when I was using these headphones. In terms of the materials used, they are not at the level of my daily driver, the M50XBT. However, at ₹8,490 it is definitely bang on. The earcups are mostly plastic and have very few points of failure if you are planning to stress these out to the max when using them.

FEATURES

These are not the most feature-packed headphones. The controls on the left earcup are responsive and intuitive. The pairing process is simple, and the audio indicators, when triggered, do their job well. When you plug in the 3.5 mm cable that is supplied along with the headphones, they automatically turn off, and when you remove the cable, if the headphones were on, they turn back on again. Additionally, Audio-Technica has included multi-point connectivity on these headphones, which makes sure that



you can switch between your devices easily. There's also a low latency mode, which gamers would love. Although, I could not figure out how to trigger it. There's no ANC or any other features that are generally seen on Bluetooth headphones around this price which could be a deal breaker for many.

PERFORMANCE

When it comes to performance, the Audio Technica ATHM20XBT shows its true colours. It is not something that you'd compare to their flagship products or for that matter, some other similarly priced headphones that are made by brands like Sony, JBL, and the like. The sound signature is not something that would appeal to purists or audiophiles. The dip in the low frequencies means that the sound that you get from these headphones will lack that thump. The bass hasn't completely been neutered, but in the low-bass frequencies, there's a significant drop, which would eat into your experience of watching explosions

or backing sounds of kick drums in some tracks. If you are someone looking to get your taste of how studio headphones sound without breaking the bank, then you should definitely go for these headphones. The sound signature of these headphones is sufficiently close to neutral. If you are listening to podcasts, the boost in the mids also ensures that you get crystal-clear vocals despite the presence of a backing track in podcast recordings. We'd have loved it if it had additional codecs supported, at least aptX. As for the microphone, it is nothing special. It is serviceable for calls and will hold its ground when you are on conference calls but don't expect anything extraordinary.

BATTERY LIFE

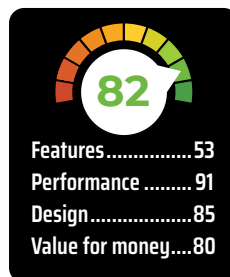
In our tests, the battery life came pretty close to the claimed numbers. To be precise, it was about 56 hours, at 50 per cent volume. The brand claims that in a 10-minute charge, you can get up to three hours of listening time.

VERDICT

Should you go for it? Yes, if you are out looking for a pair of headphones that will serve you well for years, you don't mind playing around with EQ settings on third-party apps and are looking for headphones that could be your gateway into

the world of professional headphones and audio. Now, if you are looking for an experience that has a lot of features, ANC, and app support, with a design that looks more in tune to be worn in public, then you can look at – Jabra Elite 45H, Sennheiser HD458 ANC, JBL Tune 760NC, and Sony WH-CH720N.

–Satvik Pandey



SPECIFICATIONS

Type: Closed-back dynamic | Driver Diameter: 40 mm | Sensitivity: 100 dB/mW | Impedance: 36 ohms | Weight Approx.: 216 g (7.6 oz) | Charging Time: Approx. 4 hours | Microphone Polar Pattern: Omnidirectional

CONTACT

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